Covishield. In order to honour those agreements, SII would need to export vaccines while simultaneously supplying them domestically. Diplomatically, it was also in the best strategic interest of the Indian government to help out nations in times of such a global crisis. Poonawalla also raised an interesting point at a later date in 2021 when I spoke with him,

> Look, very early on in the pandemic, I decided to raise stakes to secure India. I tied up with various organizations to come up with a vaccine which had three important components: technological ease of production, one which wouldn't require cold-chain transport and a product which was cost-effective and affordable for middle-and low-income countries. Tell me, what is the value of ₹250 today? That's the cost of my vaccine. Based on these, I raised money early from international network so that I could get a head-start in the production process and secure India as soon as possible. Look at the speed with which we raised infrastructure! SII supplies to over 150 nations worldwide. Many of these markets have only recently opened up to the Indian pharmaceutical industry, which benefits us as a whole. In order to retain our supply chains in those markets—even from a security standpoint, the vaccine export initiative by the Indian government was absolutely critical.

All in all, we began to provide our neighbouring nations and other key partner countries with vaccine doses—both Covaxin and Covishield. Several of those beneficiary nations were able to initiate their vaccine drives because of receiving vaccines from India.

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**26 JANUARY 2021**

INDIA | 1,77,119 ACTIVE CASES | 1,53,368 DEATHS | 80 LAKH VACCINE DOSES

WORLD | 1,83,02,463 ACTIVE CASES | 21,46,252 DEATHS | 4.68 CRORE VACCINE DOSES

While India was making steady progress in its vaccination drive, several noteworthy political developments were taking place too. Protesting groups